HEROES OF NORMANDIE

The Devil Pig News

Number 6 (I am not a number, I am a free man) www.devil-pig-games.com December 2016

AND BY THE WAY, HOW ARE YOU ?

THE IMPORTANCE OF SEEING THE GLASS HALF FULL IN TIME OF WAR

I have met some sergeants...
Big ones, small ones, tall ones. All of them yelling louder than the other ones. Always on your back, always trying to humiliate you, to bury you on the ground. During the training, we couldn't stand them. On our way to England, we couldn't stand them... In England, in our barracks, we couldn't stand them. On the other hand, on D-Day in Normandie, all our guys were glad to have the Sergeant with us. This is where we understood what these bastards were for.

One day, in June.

It was very early, too early, when the gentle yet explosive voice of our woke us up. Most of us just managed to fall in a very agitated sleep. We had a hard time falling asleep, our heads spinning at the idea of what would happen the following day. The D-day!
We gathered our gear, and he kicked us out of the barracks with the kindness of a mother who just learnt we set the neighbour's barn on fire. I've managed to duck a slap from the Sergeant who thought I wasn't fast enough. I'm from the South, see, from Louisiana to be precise. Hurrying isn't really my thing. For months, he had me in his crosshairs because of that, and now, I saw that he was cracking a bit under the pressure. He didn't show anything, but to me, this ducked slap was a proof of the intense strain that possessed him.

We boarded a boat, I can't remember its name, all the military company, soldiers, officers, and sergeants, of course... We were packed like sheep on a farm fair. We barely had enough space to stretch our legs. It was cold and we were already soaked. Some guys were screaming «Ivy! Ivy! Ivy!» to give themselves courage. We are from the 4th, Steadfast and Loyal...

We landed on Utah Beach. It was like a preview of hell, though we later heard than the guys at Omaha suffered worse than hell. We suffered a few light weapons shots, and a couple of positions were tough nuts to crack. But them, they left 2000 friends on the sand. This is were we saw for the first time what a sergeant brings to its unit.

Ours was everywhere, pulling a guy from his whole right before a bombshell exploded, pushing another one from the firing range of a MG42, yelling at another who was sobbing, holding his weapon. He took Steinberg and Roberts with him to get around a machine gun nest which covered our positions. The 3 of them – well, him mostly – shut it in time. We got up to overcome the dune while it fired its very last blast. It is thanks to him that we only lost one man on this assault. Then, on the road towards Sainte Marie du Mont, he got us out of trouble once more when he spotted a German patrol before it fired. He jumped on them, waving his Thompson, they yielded. Just like that, without any hesitation... Me and the guys, we were in awe. We celebrated our Sergeant. It was the first time we told him nice things. He was dumbstruck... Well, this didn't stop him from howling at us so we didn't stay in the middle of the path. Coincidentally, we left the road seconds before a mortar fire exploded where we stood. Sergeants must have a pretty good sixth sense!

He then had us run through these fucking Normandie hedges that surround fields, the "bocage", as they say. This is the worst thing there is when you're on the assailant side. But on the defense side, it's easy peasy.
You're hidden, you see a company barging in, they're clueless, you fire at them, they replicate, and when it's becoming too dangerous for you, you get the hell out, and start over a couple of fields further down.

We were the assailants here. Our sergeant found a little trick that allowed us to save a bunch of lives. I can't recall the details specifically, but our Lieutenant made a memo out of it that he sent to General Staff. Considering what happened to other companies, we can imagine it got lost on the desk of one of these pen-pushers from Head Quarters.
I have the feeling that we ran non-stop until Sainte-Mère-église. We stopped when we joined the guys from the 101st. They got hit real bad since their airdrop. Between those stuck in trees, in street



lamps, those we fished out of swamped lakes and those lying in ditches, it's been a massacre. There were dozens of wounded who piled up in the houses we turned in field hospitals. We left the town to go clean up the Cotentin peninsula, we then took Avranches. During this whole Normandie campaign, he saved my ass 3 times. At the end, we were on first name basis, he was called Will. I had made efforts to hurry up a bit more. The fact that I spoke a bit of French helped me make a better impression with him. I was a veteran and an important element of my section.

We freed Paris. With Ernest Hemingway. The binge of a lifetime! A 3 days long party, with girls and booze, before leaving again on our way to Belgium. When arriving to
Houffalize to attack the Siegfried line, Steinberg, 2 guys who took care of the 30 caliber, a crazy Texan, Will and I were the only ones left from our section. All the others were dead, or too wounded to go return to combat. The new guys arrived with the sergeant hatred at heart, but it never took them more than a week to



change their mind. Between our stories, and his remarkable deeds, he won their respect as quickly as they were shot down by the krauts. We preferred not to know their name, because we knew that out of 2 rookies, one wouldn't spend Christmas with us. But our Sergeant did his best to reassure them, and mostly to keep them alive.

Sometimes, I would see him at night, in his tent, crying over his bottle because of a kid he couldn't save from the german bullets. As if this was a God given mission. I don't know how he held on. The more guys he lost, the more he drank. Once or twice, I had to take command and run the section because he was too drunk. I never told the Lieutenant, I had too much respect for our Sergeant. We owed him too much to rat him out this way. Sometimes, I tell myself that what happened on the very first day of the German attack in the Ardennes was the best thing that could happen to him. Sober, he would check our ditches, yelling as he did in our first days, giving advice, digging with us. I found my Sergeant back. And that gave me the impression that I was gonna get out of this. That we would all get out of this. He was up and standing, wrists on his hips, screaming at a rookie when it happened. His legs went right, his torso went left. He didn't suffer.



The day after I was appointed sergeant, and I wanted to believe I was as good as him, to accomplish this God given mission.

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